

LOW TIDE ON GRAND PRÉ

LOW TIDE ON GRAND PRÉ:
A BOOK OF LYRICS:
BY
BLISS CARMAN



CHARLES L. WEBSTER AND COMPANY
PUBLISHERS NEW YORK MDCCCXCIII

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GRAND PRÉ: A BOOK OF LYRICS ***

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The poems in this volume have been collected with reference to their similarity of tone. They are variations on a single theme, more or less aptly suggested by the title, *Low Tide on Grand Pré*. It seemed better to bring together between the same covers only those pieces of work which happened to be in the same key, rather than to publish a larger book of more uncertain aim.

B. C.

By Grand Pré, September, 1893.

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TO

S. M. C.

Spiritus haeres sit patriae quae tristia nescit.

LOW TIDE ON GRAND PRÉ

The sun goes down, and over all
These barren reaches by the tide
Such unelusive glories fall,
I almost dream they yet will bide
Until the coming of the tide.

And yet I know that not for us,
By any ecstasy of dream,
He lingers to keep luminous
A little while the grievous stream,
Which frets, uncomfited of dream—

A grievous stream, that to and fro
Athrough the fields of Acadie
Goes wandering, as if to know
Why one beloved face should be
So long from home and Acadie.

Was it a year or lives ago
We took the grasses in our hands,
And caught the summer flying low
Over the waving meadow lands,
And held it there between our hands?

The while the river at our feet—
A drowsy inland meadow stream—
At set of sun the after-heat
Made running gold, and in the gleam
We freed our birch upon the stream.

There down along the elms at dusk
We lifted dripping blade to drift,
Through twilight scented fine like musk,
Where night and gloom awhile uplift,
Nor sunder soul and soul adrift.

And that we took into our hands
Spirit of life or subtler thing—

WHY

For a name unknown,
Whose fame unblown
Sleeps in the hills
For ever and aye;

For her who hears
The stir of the years
Go by on the wind
By night and day;

And heeds no thing
Of the needs of spring,
Of autumn's wonder
Or winter's chill;

For one who sees
The great sun freeze,
As he wanders a-cold
From hill to hill;

And all her heart
Is a woven part
Of the flurry and drift
Of whirling snow;

For the sake of two
Sad eyes and true,
And the old, old love
So long ago.

THE UNRETURNING

The old eternal spring once more
Comes back the sad eternal way,
With tender rosy light before
The going-out of day.

The great white moon across my door
A shadow in the twilight stirs;
But now forever comes no more
That wondrous look of Hers.

A WINDFLOWER

Between the roadside and the wood,
Between the dawning and the dew,
A tiny flower before the sun,
Ephemeral in time, I grew.

And there upon the trail of spring,
Not death nor love nor any name
Known among men in all their lands
Could blur the wild desire with shame.

But down my dayspan of the year
The feet of straying winds came by;
And all my trembling soul was thrilled
To follow one lost mountain cry.

And then my heart beat once and broke
To hear the sweeping rain forebode
Some ruin in the April world,
Between the woodside and the road.

To-night can bring no healing now;
The calm of yesternight is gone;
Surely the wind is but the wind,
And I a broken waif thereon.

IN LYRIC SEASON

The lyric April time is forth
With lyric mornings, frost and sun;
From leaguers vast of night undone
Auroral mild new stars are born.

And ever at the year's return,
Along the valleys gray with rime,
Thou leadest as of old, where time
Can naught but follow to thy sway.

The trail is far through leagues of spring,
And long the quest to the white core
Of harvest quiet, yet once more
I gird me to the old unrest.

I know I shall not ever meet
Thy still regard across the year,
And yet I know thou wilt draw near,
When the last hour of pain and loss

Drifts out to slumber, and the deeps
Of nightfall feel God's hand unbar
His lyric April, star by star,
And the lost twilight land reveal.

THE PENSIONERS

We are the pensioners of Spring,
And take the largess of her hand
When vassal warder winds unbar
The wintry portals of her land;

The lonely shadow-girdled winds,
Her seraph almoners, who keep
This little life in flesh and bone
With meagre portions of white sleep.

Then all year through with starveling care
We go on some fool's idle quest,
And eat her bread and wine in thrall
To a fool's shame with blind unrest.

Until her April train goes by,
And then because we are the kin
Of every hill flower on the hill
We must arise and walk therein.

Because her heart as our own heart,
Knowing the same wild upward stir,
Beats joyward by eternal laws,
We must arise and go with her;

Forget we are not where old joys
Return when dawns and dreams retire;
Make grief a phantom of regret,
And fate the henchman of desire;

Divorce unreason from delight;
Learn how despair is uncontrol,
Failure the shadow of remorse,
And death a shudder of the soul.

Yea, must we triumph when she leads.
A little rain before the sun,
A breath of wind on the road's dust,
The sound of trampled brooks undone

AT THE VOICE OF A BIRD

Consurgent ad vocem volucris.

Call to me, thrush,
When night grows dim,
When dreams unform
And death is far!

When hoar dews flush
On dawn's rathe brim,
Wake me to hear
Thy wildwood charm,

As a lone rush
Astir in the slim
White stream where sheer
Blue mornings are.

Stir the keen hush
On twilight's rim
When my own star
Is white and clear.

Fly low to brush
Mine eyelids grim,
Where sleep and storm
Will set their bar;

For God shall crush
Spring balm for him,
Stark on his bier
Past fault or harm,

Who once, as flush
Of day might skim
The dusk, afar
In sleep shall hear

Thy song's cool rush
With joy rebrim
The world, and calm
The deep with cheer

WHEN THE GUELDER ROSES BLOOM

When the Guelder roses bloom,
Love, the vagrant, wanders home.

Love, that died so long ago,
As we deemed, in dark and snow,

Comes back to the door again,
Guendolen, Guendolen.

In his hands a few bright flowers,
Gathered in the earlier hours,

Speedwell-blue, and poppy-red,
Withered in the sun and dead,

With a history to each,
Are more eloquent than speech.

In his eyes the welling tears
Plead against the lapse of years.

And that mouth we knew so well,
Hath a pilgrim's tale to tell.

Hear his litany again:
"Guendolen, Guendolen!"

"No, love, no, thou art a ghost!
Love long since in night was lost.

"Thou art but the shade of him,
For thine eyes are sad and dim."

"Nay, but they will shine once more,
Glad and brighter than before,

"If thou bring me but again
To my mother Guendolen!

~~~~~

"These dark flowers are for thee,  
Gathered by the lonely sea.

"And these singing shells for her  
Who first called me wanderer,

"In whose beauty glad I grew,  
When this weary life was new."

Hear him raving! "It is I.  
Love once born can never die."

"Thou, poor love, thou art gone mad  
With the hardships thou hast had.

"True, it is the spring of year,  
But thy mother is not here.

"True, the Guelder roses bloom  
As long since about this room,

"Where thy blessed self was born  
In the early golden morn

"But the years are dead, good lack!  
Ah, love, why hast thou come back,

"Pleading at the door again,  
'Guendolen, Guendolen'?"

When the Guelder roses bloom,  
And the vernal stars resume

Their old purple sweep and range,  
I can hear a whisper strange

As the wind gone daft again,  
"Guendolen, Guendolen!"

"When the Guelder roses blow

When the Guelder roses blow,  
Love that died so long ago,

"Why wilt thou return so oft,  
With that whisper sad and soft

"On thy pleading lips again,  
'Guendolen, Guendolen'!"

Still the Guelder roses bloom,  
And the sunlight fills the room,

Where love's shadow at the door  
Falls upon the dusty floor.

And his eyes are sad and grave  
With the tenderness they crave,

Seeing in the broken rhyme  
The significance of time,

Wondrous eyes that know not sin  
From his brother death, wherein

I can see thy look again,  
Guendolen, Guendolen.

And love with no more to say,  
In this lovely world to-day

Where the Guelder roses bloom,  
Than the record on a tomb,

Only moves his lips again,  
"Guendolen, Guendolen!"

Then he passes up the road  
From this dwelling, where he bode

In the by-gone years. And still.

## SEVEN THINGS

The fields of earth are sown  
From the hand of the striding rain,  
And kernels of joy are strewn  
Abroad for the harrow of pain.

I.

The first song-sparrow brown  
That wakes the earliest spring,  
When time and fear sink down,  
And death is a fabled thing.

## II.

The stealing of that first dawn  
Over the rosy brow,  
When thy soul said, "World, fare on,  
For Heaven is here and now!"

### III.

The crimson shield of the sun  
On the wall of this House of Doom,  
With the garb of war undone  
At last in the narrow room.

#### IV.

A heart that abides to the end,  
As the hills for sureness and peace,  
And is neither weary to wend  
Nor reluctant at last of release.

V.

Thy mother's cradle croon  
To haunt thee over the deep,  
Out of the land of Boon  
Into the land of Sleep.

VI.

The sound of the sea in storm,  
Hearing its captain cry,  
When the wild, white riders form,  
And the Ride to the Dark draws nigh.

VII.

But last and best, the urge  
Of the great world's desire,  
Whose being from core to verge  
Only attains to aspire.

## A SEA CHILD

The lover of child Marjory  
    Had one white hour of life brim full;  
Now the old nurse, the rocking sea,  
    Hath him to lull.

The daughter of child Marjory  
    Hath in her veins, to beat and run,  
The glad indomitable sea,  
    The strong white sun.

PULVIS ET UMBRA

There is dust upon my fingers,  
Pale gray dust of beaten wings,  
Where a great moth came and settled  
From the night's blown winnowings.

Harvest with her low red planets  
Wheeling over Arrochar;  
And the lonely hopeless calling  
Of the bell-buoy on the bar,

Where the sea with her old secret  
Moves in sleep and cannot rest.  
From that dark beyond my doorway,  
Silent the unbidden guest

Came and tarried, fearless, gentle,  
Vagrant of the starlit gloom,  
One frail waif of beauty fronting  
Immortality and doom;

Through the chambers of the twilight  
Roaming from the vast outland,  
Resting for a thousand heart-beats  
In the hollow of my hand.

"Did the volley of a thrush-song  
Lodge among some leaves and dew  
Hillward, then across the gloaming  
This dark mottled thing was you?

"Or is my mute guest whose coming  
So unheralded befell  
From the border wilds of dreamland,  
Only whimsy Ariel,

"Gleaning with the wind, in furrows  
Lonelier than dawn to reap,  
Dust and shadow and forgetting,  
Frost and reverie and sleep?

frost and reverie and sleep:

"In the hush when Cleopatra  
Felt the darkness reel and cease,  
Was thy soul a wan blue lotus  
Laid upon her lips for peace?

"And through all the years that wayward  
Passion in one mortal breath,  
Making thee a thing of silence,  
Made thee as the lords of death?

"Or did goblin men contrive thee  
In the forges of the hills  
Out of thistle-drift and sundown  
Lost amid their tawny rills,

"Every atom on their anvil  
Beaten fine and bolted home,  
Every quiver wrought to cadence  
From the rapture of a gnome?

"Then the lonely mountain wood-wind,  
Straying up from dale to dale,  
Gave thee spirit, free forever,  
Thou immortal and so frail!

"Surely thou art not that sun-bright  
Psyche, hoar with age, and hurled  
On the northern shore of Lethe,  
To this wan Auroral world!

"Ghost of Psyche, uncompanioned,  
Are the yester-years all done?  
Have the oars of Charon ferried  
All thy playmates from the sun?

"In thy wings the beat and breathing  
Of the wind of life abides,

And the night whose sea-gray cohorts  
Swing the stars up with the tides.

"Did they once make sail and wander  
Through the trembling harvest sky,  
Where the silent Northern streamers  
Change and rest not till they die?

"Or from clouds that tent and people  
The blue firmamental waste,  
Did they learn the noiseless secret  
Of eternity's unhaste?

"Where learned they to rove and loiter,  
By the margin of what sea?  
Was it with outworn Demeter,  
Searching for Persephone?

"Or did that girl-queen behold thee  
In the fields of moveless air?  
Did these wings which break no whisper  
Brush the poppies in her hair?

"Is it thence they wear the pulvil—  
Ash of ruined days and sleep,  
And the two great orbs of splendid  
Melting sable deep on deep!

"Pilot of the shadow people,  
Steering whither by what star  
Hast thou come to hapless port here,  
Thou gray ghost of Arrochar?"

For man walks the world with mourning  
Down to death, and leaves no trace,  
With the dust upon his forehead,  
And the shadow in his face.

Pillared dust and fleeing shadow

Flashed dust and fleeting shadow,  
As the roadside wind goes by,  
And the fourscore years that vanish  
In the twinkling of an eye.

Beauty, the fine frosty trace-work  
Of some breath upon the pane;  
Spirit, the keen wintry moonlight  
Flashed thereon to fade again.

Beauty, the white clouds a-building  
When God said and it was done;  
Spirit, the sheer brooding rapture  
Where no mid-day brooks no sun.

So. And here, the open casement  
Where my fellow-mate goes free;  
Eastward, the untrodden star-road  
And the long wind on the sea.

What's to hinder but I follow  
This my gypsy guide afar,  
When the bugle rouses slumber  
Sounding taps on Arrochar?

"Where, my brother, wends the by-way,  
To what bourne beneath what sun,  
Thou and I are set to travel  
Till the shifting dream be done?

"Comrade of the dusk, forever  
I pursue the endless way  
Of the dust and shadow kindred,  
Thou art perfect for a day.

"Yet from beauty marred and broken,  
Joy and memory and tears,  
I shall crush the clearer honey  
In the harvest of the years.

## THROUGH THE TWILIGHT

The red vines bar my window way;  
The Autumn sleeps beside his fire,  
For he has sent this fleet-foot day  
A year's march back to bring to me  
One face whose smile is my desire,  
Its light my star.

Surely you will come near and speak,  
This calm of death from the day to sever!  
And so I shall draw down your cheek  
Close to my face—So close!—and know  
God's hand between our hands forever  
Will set no bar.

Before the dusk falls—even now  
I know your step along the gravel,  
And catch your quiet poise of brow,  
And wait so long till you turn the latch!  
Is the way so hard you had to travel?  
Is the land so far?

The dark has shut your eyes from mine,  
But in this hush of brooding weather  
A gleam on twilight's gathering line  
Has riven the barriers of dream:  
Soul of my soul, we are together  
As the angels are!

## CARNATIONS IN WINTER

Your carmine flakes of bloom to-night  
The fire of wintry sunsets hold;  
Again in dreams you burn to light  
A far Canadian garden old.

The blue north summer over it  
Is bland with long ethereal days;  
The gleaming martins wheel and flit  
Where breaks your sun down orient ways.

There, when the gradual twilight falls,  
Through quietudes of dusk afar,  
Hermit antiphonal hermit calls  
From hills below the first pale star.

Then in your passionate love's foredoom  
Once more your spirit stirs the air,  
And you are lifted through the gloom  
To warm the coils of her dark hair.

# A NORTHERN VIGIL

Here by the gray north sea,  
In the wintry heart of the wild,  
Comes the old dream of thee,  
Guendolen, mistress and child.

The heart of the forest grieves  
In the drift against my door;  
A voice is under the eaves,  
A footfall on the floor.

Threshold, mirror and hall,  
Vacant and strangely aware,  
Wait for their soul's recall  
With the dumb expectant air.

Here when the smouldering west  
Burns down into the sea,  
I take no heed of rest  
And keep the watch for thee.

I sit by the fire and hear  
The restless wind go by,  
On the long dirge and drear,  
Under the low bleak sky.

When day puts out to sea  
And night makes in for land,  
There is no lock for thee,  
Each door awaits thy hand!

When night goes over the hill  
And dawn comes down the dale,  
It's O for the wild sweet will  
That shall no more prevail!

When the zenith moon is round,  
And snow-wraiths gather and run,  
And there is set no bound  
To love beneath the sun

TO LOVE BENEATH THE SUN,

O wayward will, come near  
The old mad willful way,  
The soft mouth at my ear  
With words too sweet to say!

Come, for the night is cold,  
The ghostly moonlight fills  
Hollow and rift and fold  
Of the eerie Ardisse hills!

The windows of my room  
Are dark with bitter frost,  
The stillness aches with doom  
Of something loved and lost.

Outside, the great blue star  
Burns in the ghostland pale,  
Where giant Algebar  
Holds on the endless trail.

Come, for the years are long,  
And silence keeps the door,  
Where shapes with the shadows throng  
The firelit chamber floor.

Come, for thy kiss was warm,  
With the red embers' glare  
Across thy folding arm  
And dark tumultuous hair!

And though thy coming rouse  
The sleep-cry of no bird,  
The keepers of the house  
Shall tremble at thy word.

Come, for the soul is free!  
In all the vast dreamland

# THE EAVESDROPPER

In a still room at hush of dawn,  
My Love and I lay side by side  
And heard the roaming forest wind  
Stir in the paling autumn-tide.

I watched her earth-brown eyes grow glad  
Because the round day was so fair;  
While memories of reluctant night  
Lurked in the blue dusk of her hair.

Outside, a yellow maple tree,  
Shifting upon the silvery blue  
With small innumerable sound,  
Rustled to let the sunlight through.

The livelong day the elvish leaves  
Danced with their shadows on the floor;  
And the lost children of the wind  
Went straying homeward by our door.

And all the swarthy afternoon  
We watched the great deliberate sun  
Walk through the crimsoned hazy world,  
Counting his hilltops one by one.

Then as the purple twilight came  
And touched the vines along our eaves,  
Another Shadow stood without  
And gloomed the dancing of the leaves.

The silence fell on my Love's lips;  
Her great brown eyes were veiled and sad  
With pondering some maze of dream,  
Though all the splendid year was glad.

Restless and vague as a gray wind  
Her heart had grown, she knew not why.  
But hurrying to the open door,  
Against the verge of western sky

## IN APPLE TIME

The apple harvest days are here,  
The boding apple harvest days,  
And down the flaming valley ways,  
The foresters of time draw near.

Through leagues of bloom I went with Spring,  
To call you on the slopes of morn,  
Where in imperious song is borne  
The wild heart of the golden wing.

I roamed through alien summer lands,  
I sought your beauty near and far;  
To-day, where russet shadows are,  
I hold your face between my hands.

On runnels dark by slopes of fern,  
The hazy undern sleeps in sun.  
Remembrance and desire, undone,  
From old regret to dreams return.

The apple harvest time is here,  
The tender apple harvest time;  
A sheltering calm, unknown at prime,  
Settles upon the brooding year.

WANDERER

# I

Wanderer, wanderer, whither away?  
What saith the morning unto thee?  
"Wanderer, wanderer, hither, come hither,  
Into the eld of the East with me!"

Saith the wide wind of the low red morning,  
Making in from the gray rough sea.  
"Wanderer, come, of the footfall weary,  
And heavy at heart as the sad-heart sea.

"For long ago, when the world was making,  
I walked through Eden with God for guide;  
And since that time in my heart forever  
His calm and wisdom and peace abide.

"I am thy spirit and thy familiar,  
Child of the teeming earth's unrest!  
Before God's joy upon gloom begot thee  
I had hungered and searched and ended the quest.

"I sit by the roadside wells of knowledge;  
I haunt the streams of the springs of thought;  
But because my voice is the voice of silence,  
The heart within thee regardeth not.

"Yet I await thee, assured, unimpatient,  
Till thy small tumult of striving be past.  
How long, O wanderer, wilt thou a-weary,  
Keep thee afar from my arms at the last?"

## II

Wanderer, wanderer, whither away?  
What saith the high noon unto thee?  
"Wanderer, wanderer, hither, turn hither,  
Far to the burning South with me,"

Saith the soft wind on the high June headland,  
Sheering up from the summer sea,  
"While the implacable warder, Oblivion,  
Sleeps on the marge of a foamless sea!

"Come where the urge of desire availeth,  
And no fear follows the children of men;  
For a handful of dust is the only heirloom  
The morrow bequeaths to its morrow again.

"Touch and feel how the flesh is perfect  
Beyond the compass of dream to be!  
'Bone of my bone,' said God to Adam;  
'Core of my core,' say I to thee.

"Look and see how the form is goodly  
Beyond the reach of desire and art!  
For he who fashioned the world so easily  
Laughed in his sleeve as he walked apart.

"Therefore, O wanderer, cease from desiring;  
Take the wide province of seaway and sun!  
Here for the infinite quench of thy craving,  
Infinite yearning and bliss are one."

### III

Wanderer, wanderer, whither away?  
What saith the evening unto thee?  
"Wanderer, wanderer, hither, haste hither,  
Into the glad-heart West with me!"

Saith the strong wind of the gold-green twilight,  
Gathering out of the autumn hills,  
"I am the word of the world's first dreamer  
Who woke when Freedom walked on the hills.

"And the secret triumph from daring to doing,  
From musing to marble, I will be,  
Till the last fine fleck of the world is finished,  
And Freedom shall walk alone by the sea.

"Who is thy heart's lord, who is thy hero?  
Bruce or Cæsar or Charlemagne,  
Hannibal, Olaf, Alaric, Roland?  
Dare as they dared and the deed's done again!

"Here where they come of the habit immortal,  
By the open road to the land of the Name,  
Splendor and homage and wealth await thee  
Of builded cities and bruited fame.

"Let loose the conquering toiler within thee;  
Know the large rapture of deeds begun!  
The joy of the hand that hews for beauty  
Is the dearest solace beneath the sun."

#### IV

Wanderer, wanderer, whither away?  
What saith the midnight unto thee?  
"Wanderer, wanderer, hither turn home,  
Back to thy North at last to me!"

Saith the great forest wind and lonely,  
Out of the stars and the wintry hills.  
"Weary, bethink thee of rest, and remember  
Thy waiting auroral Ardise hills!

"Was it not I, when thy mother bore thee  
In the sweet, solemn April night,  
Took thee safe in my arms to fondle,  
Filled thy dream with the old delight?

"Told thee tales of more marvelous summers  
Of the far away and the long ago,  
Made thee my own nurse-child forever  
In the tender dear dark land of the snow?

"Have I not rocked thee, have I not lulled thee,  
Crooned thee in forest, and cradled in foam,  
Then with a smile from the hearthstone of childhood  
Bade thee farewell when thy heart bade thee roam?

"Ah, my wide-wanderer, thou blessed vagrant,  
Dear will thy footfall be nearing my door.  
How the glad tears will give vent at thy coming,  
Wayward or sad-heart to wander no more!"

V

Morning and midday I wander, and evening,  
April and harvest and golden fall;  
Seaway or hillward, taut sheet or saddle-bow,  
Only the night wind brings solace at all.

Then when the tide of all being and beauty  
Ebbs to the utmost before the first dawn,  
Comes the still voice of the morrow revealing  
Inscrutable valorous hope—and is gone.

Therefore is joy more than sorrow, foreseeing  
The lust of the mind and the lure of the eye  
And the pride of the hand have their hour of triumph,  
But the dream of the heart will endure by-and-by.

AFOOT

There's a garden in the South  
Where the early violets come,  
Where they strew the floor of April  
With their purple, bloom by bloom.

There the tender peach-trees blow,  
Pink against the red brick wall,  
And the hand of twilight hushes  
The rain-children's least footfall,

Till at midnight I can hear  
The dark Mother croon and lean  
Close above me. And her whisper  
Bids the vagabonds convene.

Then the glad and wayward heart  
Dreams a dream it must obey;  
And the wanderer within me  
Stirs a foot and will not stay.

I would journey far and wide  
Through the provinces of spring,  
Where the gorgeous white azaleas  
Hear the sultry yorlin sing.

I would wander all the hills  
Where my fellow-vagrants wend,  
Following the trails of shadows  
To the country where they end.

Well I know the gypsy kin,  
Roving foot and restless hand,  
And the eyes in dark elusion  
Dreaming down the summer land.

On the frontier of desire  
I will drink the last regret,  
And then forth beyond the morrow  
Where I may but half forget

# WAYFARING

Across the harbor's tangled yards  
We watch the flaring sunset fail;  
Then the forever questing stars  
File down along the vanished trail,

To no discovered country, where  
They will forgather when the hands  
Of the strong Fates shall take away  
Their burdens and unloose their bands.

Westward and lone the hill-road gray  
Mounts to the skyline sheer and wan,  
Where many a weary dream puts forth  
To strike the trail where they are gone.

The sleepless guide to that outland  
Is the great Mother of us all,  
Whose molded dust and dew we are  
With the blown flowers by the wall.

Girt with the twilight she is grave,  
The strong companion, wise and free;  
She leads beyond the dales of time,  
The earldom of the calling sea—

Beyond these dull green miles of dike,  
And gleaming breakers on the bar—  
To the white kingdom of her lord,  
The nameless Word, whose breath we are.

And all the world is but a scheme  
Of busy children in the street,  
A play they follow and forget  
On summer evenings, pale with heat.

The dusty courtyard flags and walls  
Are like a prison gate of stone,  
To every spirit for whose breath  
The long sweet hill winds once have blown

THE LONG SWEET MILD-WINDS ONCE HAVE BLOWN.

But waiting in the fields for them  
I see the ancient Mother stand,  
With the old courage of her smile,  
The patience of her sunbrown hand.

They heed her not, until there comes  
A breath of sleep upon their eyes,  
A drift of dust upon their face;  
Then in the closing dusk they rise,

And turn them to the empty doors;  
But she within whose hands alone  
The days are gathered up as fruit,  
Doth habit not in brick and stone.

But where the wild shy things abide,  
Along the woodside and the wheat,  
Is her abiding, deep withdrawn;  
And there, the footing of her feet.

There is no common fame of her  
Upon the corners, yet some word  
Of her most secret heritage  
Her lovers from her lips have heard.

Her daisies sprang where Chaucer went;  
Her darkling nightingales with spring  
Possessed the soul of Keats for song;  
And Shelley heard her skylark sing;

With reverent clear uplifted heart  
Wordsworth beheld her daffodils;  
And he became too great for haste,  
Who watched the warm green Cumner hills.

She gave the apples of her eyes  
For the delight of him who knew,

With all the wisdom of a child,  
"A bank whereon the wild thyme grew."

Still the old secret shifts, and waits  
The last interpreter; it fills  
The autumn song no ear hath heard  
Upon the dreaming Ardise hills.

The poplars babble over it  
When waking winds of dawn go by;  
It fills her rivers like a voice,  
And leads her wanderers till they die.

She knows the morning ways whereon  
The windflowers and the wind confer;  
Surely there is not any fear  
Upon the farthest trail with her!

And yet, what ails the fir-dark slopes,  
That all night long the whippoorwills  
Cry their insatiable cry  
Across the sleeping Ardise hills?

Is it that no fair mortal thing,  
Blown leaf, nor song, nor friend can stray  
Beyond the bourne and bring one word  
Back the irremeable way?

The noise is hushed within the street;  
The summer twilight gathers down;  
The elms are still; the moonlit spires  
Track their long shadows through the town.

With looming willows and gray dusk  
The open hillward road is pale,  
And the great stars are white and few  
Above the lonely Ardise trail.

And with no haste nor any fear

# THE END OF THE TRAIL

Once more the hunters of the dusk  
Are forth to search the moorlands wide,  
Among the autumn-colored hills,  
And wander by the shifting tide.

All day along the haze-hung verge  
They scour upon a fleeing trace,  
Between the red sun and the sea,  
Where haunts the vision of your face.

The plane at Martock lies and drinks  
The long Septembral gaze of blue;  
The royal leisure of the hills  
Hath wayward reveries of you.

Far rovers of the ancient dream  
Have all their will of musing hours:  
Your eyes were gray-deep as the sea,  
Your hands lay open in the flowers!

From mining Rawdon to Pereaue,  
For all the gold they delve and share,  
The goblins of the Ardise hills  
Can horde no treasure like your hair.

The swirling tide, the lonely gulls,  
The sweet low wood-winds that rejoice—  
No sound nor echo of the sea  
But hath tradition of your voice.

The crimson leaves, the yellow fruit,  
The basking woodlands mile on mile—  
No gleam in all the russet hills  
But wears the solace of your smile.

A thousand cattle rove and feed  
On the great marshes in the sun,  
And wonder at the restless sea;  
But I am glad the year is done

But I am glad the year is done,

Because I am a wanderer  
Upon the roads of endless quest,  
Between the hill-wind and the hills,  
Along the margin men call rest.

Because there lies upon my lips  
A whisper of the wind at morn,  
A murmur of the rolling sea  
Cradling the land where I was born;

Because its sleepless tides and storms  
Are in my heart for memory  
And music, and its gray-green hills  
Run white to bear me company;

Because in that sad time of year,  
With April twilight on the earth  
And journeying rain upon the sea,  
With the shy windflowers was my birth;

Because I was a tiny boy  
Among the thrushes of the wood,  
And all the rivers in the hills  
Were playmates of my solitude;

Because the holy winter night  
Was for my chamber, deep among  
The dark pine forests by the sea,  
With woven red auroras hung,

Silent with frost and floored with snow,  
With what dream folk to people it  
And bring their stories from the hills,  
When all the splendid stars were lit;

Therefore I house me not with kin,  
But journey as the sun goes forth,

# THE VAGABONDS

"Such as wake on the night and sleep on the day, and haunt customable taverns and alehouses and routs about, and no man wot from whence they came, nor whither they go."—*Old English Statute*.

We are the vagabonds of time,  
And rove the yellow autumn days,  
When all the roads are gray with rime  
And all the valleys blue with haze.

We came unlooked for as the wind  
Trooping across the April hills,  
When the brown waking earth had dreams  
Of summer in the Wander Kills.

How far afield we joyed to fare,  
With June in every blade and tree!  
Now with the sea-wind in our hair  
We turn our faces to the sea.

We go unheeded as the stream  
That wanders by the hill-wood side,  
Till the great marshes take his hand  
And lead him to the roving tide.

The roving tide, the sleeping hills,  
These are the borders of that zone  
Where they may fare as fancy wills  
Whom wisdom smiles and calls her own.

It is a country of the sun,  
Full of forgotten yesterdays,  
When time takes Summer in his care,  
And fills the distance of her gaze.

It stretches from the open sea  
To the blue mountains and beyond;  
The world is Vagabondia  
To him who is a vagabond.

In the beginning God made man  
Out of the wandering dust, men say;  
And in the end his life shall be  
A wandering wind and blown away

A wandering wind and blown away.

We are the vagabonds of time,  
Willing to let the world go by,  
With joy supreme, with heart sublime,  
And valor in the kindling eye.

We have forgotten where we slept,  
And guess not where we sleep to-night,  
Whether among the lonely hills  
In the pale streamers' ghostly light

We shall lie down and hear the frost  
Walk in the dead leaves restlessly,  
Or somewhere on the iron coast  
Learn the oblivion of the sea.

It matters not. And yet I dream  
Of dreams fulfilled and rest somewhere  
Before this restless heart is stilled  
And all its fancies blown to air.

Had I my will!... The sun burns down  
And something plucks my garment's hem;  
The robins in their faded brown  
Would lure me to the south with them.

'Tis time for vagabonds to make  
The nearest inn. Far on I hear  
The voices of the Northern hills  
Gather the vagrants of the year.

Brave heart, my soul! Let longings be!  
We have another day to wend.  
For dark or waylay what care we  
Who have the lords of time to friend?

And if we tarry or make haste,  
The wayside sleep can hold no fear.

## WHITHER

What shall we do, dearie,  
    Dreaming such dreams?  
Will they come true, dearie?  
    Never, it seems.

Leave the wise thrush alone;  
    He knows such things.  
How rich the silences  
    Fall when he sings!

When shall we come, dearie,  
    Into that land  
Once was our home, dearie,  
    Perfect as planned?

When the wind calling us,  
    Some summer day,  
Into the long ago  
    Lures us away.

Where shall we go, dearie,  
    Wandering thus?  
Far to and fro, dearie,  
    Life leads for us.

Thou with the morrow's sun  
    Hillward and free,  
I to the vast and hoar  
    Lone of the sea.

1886-1893.

### Transcriber's Note

The original spelling and punctuation has been retained.  
Variations in hyphenation and compound words have been preserved.

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